



E-mail Etiquette

"All the inhabitants of the earth would be brought into one intellectual neighborhood."

—Alonzo Jackman, advocating an Atlantic telegraph in 1846

We seem to receive a ton of it every day, both at home and at work. And in turn, we generate and send a few ourselves every day. Some people regard it as a necessary evil, whereas some others look at it as a fine art. And there are still others who would develop withdrawal symptoms if they don't check email every few hours. Bane or a boon, e-mail has been with us for over a generation now and has transformed business communication in ways we couldn't have imagined. Today, e-mails are the most common means of formal written communication, both for communication within an organization and for communication with external stakeholders.

Despite the obvious proliferation of this medium, it is often used inappropriately or ineffectively and does not achieve the intended purpose. The purpose of this chapter is to present some e-mail etiquette—common practices that you should follow as a matter of courtesy to your stakeholders as well as to increase the effectiveness of your communication.

We first summarize some of the obvious advantages and challenges of e-mail as a medium. We then identify the common types of e-mails that you would need to use in your workplace. We then take each of these in a separate section and present some tips on writing them and increasing their effectiveness.

32.1 ADVANTAGES AND CHALLENGES OF E-MAILS

E-mails, being written communication, provide the following obvious advantages:

Provides a permanent record: As e-mails are forms of written communication, they leave behind a permanent record. E-mails are nowadays generally legally acceptable pieces of documents. This is a double-edged sword. While this increases the contractual validity of the document, you also need to be careful about the language you use in e-mails. Loose statements, bad language and false commitments in an e-mail are absolute no-no as you and your organization can be held liable for them.

Don't have to play 'phone tag': E-mails being asynchronous means of communication, you don't have to worry about whether the other person is present at the other end and if he would respond to you right away. You can send the mail when it is convenient for you and the recipient can read it and act on it when it is convenient to him. Obviously, this brings along with it all the accompanying advantages and disadvantages of asynchronous communication that we discussed in Chapter 13.

Cheap: E-mail today is among the most economical means of communication. It hardly costs you anything extra over and above a network connection (that is cheap) and given that delivery is almost instantaneous, the costs are far less than 'overnight delivery' (which, of course, is not even possible across continents). E-mail is also more convenient than physical mail in that you don't have to make that trip to the post office or lick stamps or worry about it getting lost. So, except in case of sending original documents or documents requiring signatures, e-mail can do everything that 'snail mail' can do—and that too, at the click of a mouse.

Ubiquitous: E-mails can be accessible anytime, anywhere. You can access e-mails through your mobile phones, laptops and so on. You can access e-mails in airports, at home, while in transit; you can receive alerts for incoming e-mails whenever and wherever you want. No other form of formal communication provides this flexibility.

Can handle most types of data: Whether you want to send text documents, drawings, photographs, presentations, spreadsheets, videos or voice recordings, e-mails can almost always handle all these as attachments. The online collaboration tools also allow you to share, modify and get to a common page (literally!) on these documents instantaneously. This makes e-mails suitable for technical communication (drawings, diagrams, etc.), business communication (contracts, spreadsheets, etc.), marketing communication (brochures, photographs, presentations, etc.) and just about anything else. Again, no other mode of formal communication can provide this much variety and such convenience at so little cost.

The challenges faced in e-mails arise by virtue of the fact that it is an asynchronous mode of communication and therefore, there is a time lag between when we send our communication and when the other party responds. Also, e-mail does not have a face-to-face component, thereby depriving the use of the body-language channel and the voice

channel. In addition, you have no way to judge the recipients' moods or his immediate reaction. Words will have to speak for themselves, and this places that much more of a burden on you, the writer of the e-mail, to achieve the objectives of communication by just the written words, without any other help and without any immediate feedback.

In addition, because e-mails can be forwarded and copied way beyond your (the author's) control, your e-mail may land up with completely uninterested or even unintended and unauthorized people. Hence you have to be extremely careful about what you say in e-mails, to prevent misuse in unauthorized hands.

32.2 COMMON TYPES OF MAILS IN PROFESSIONAL ENVIRONMENTS

In business environments, there are a number of types of e-mails that are generated. Among all these, the most common types are:

Enquiry e-mails: You would need to find out information needed for your work from your colleagues, partners or customers. Enquiry e-mails serve this purpose.

Problem reporting e-mails: You may have to report problems in someone's product, complain about inadequate customer support or anything that does not meet the expectations. Problem reporting e-mails serve this purpose.

Problem response e-mails: This is at the other end of the spectrum for the previous category. When someone complains about your product or service, you would have to respond back with a problem response e-mail.

Status reports: We have already seen about status reporting in detail in Chapter 26. Most status reports are sent by e-mail.

Meeting minutes: Just like status reports, we have also discussed in detail how to document minutes of a meeting. Again, most of the meeting minutes are sent via e-mail as the participants are usually geographically distributed and the meetings are usually virtual meetings or conference calls.

Each of these types of mails requires different etiquette which we will discuss in the individual sections. We will first discuss some common etiquette to be followed, regardless of the type of mail.

32.3 COMMON POINTS ABOUT ALL TYPES OF E-MAILS

No matter what type of e-mail you send, some points will have to be borne in mind. We will cover these in this section and then take up specific points about each type of mail separately.

Conversational style: Your e-mail should have a conversational style and should engage the recipient. Since you don't have access to valuable channels like body

language, vocal variety and so on, the words of your written text should do the trick. The choice of words and the punctuation should clearly reflect the substance of the e-mail.

'Subject' line of your e-mail: It should concisely and unambiguously indicate to the recipient what is in store in the e-mail. It should be a compelling invitation to the receiver to open the mail. We all receive loads of mail everyday. Any subject that looks like spam (or a mail with no subject line) is an easy victim of not being opened and of being deleted ruthlessly (see Box 32.1).

Box 32.1

Some Common Mistakes in Etiquette in the Subject Line

The biggest cardinal sin is to leave the subject line blank. This is an invitation for the recipient not to open your mail. After all, if you as the sender do not think it fit to specify what the subject is, why should the recipient care to open your mail? A senior management person typically receives hundreds of mails per day. Out of these, crisis mails catch their attention with a compelling subject line and become the first targets to be opened. Then there may be the routine status and project mails which come from known people, which will catch his attention. If you are sending an enquiry email to someone and if your mail ID is not familiar to him, then you need to go the extra mile to make him open the mail. A blank subject line is not likely to entice someone to open the e-mail.

Another common mistake people make is to have the subject line as 'Hi' or 'Hello'. No one wants to take the time to open such mails from a stranger. Also, this subject line is too casual to be fit for a professional business environment.

Today, most of us receive a lot of spam messages with titles like 'Your Order', 'Invoice Enclosed', and so on. Such subject lines are likely to not even pass through the 'spam filters' in most organizations.

Thus, choosing an effective subject line is an extremely important rating factor in determining the effectiveness of e-mail. Just like most resumés get filtered in the resumé screening stage itself, an ineffective subject line like the ones above is a surefire way of ensuring the recipient does not even open your e-mail.

Addressing the person: You must address the person appropriately. If the recipient is your colleague—no matter what level of seniority he is in—an informal 'Dear Bill' should be fine. First make sure you know what his first name is and how he would like to be called and use that appropriately. If the recipient is a customer or somebody with whom you have to maintain a formal distance, than a 'Dear Mr Gates' is

appropriate. But, if you have been corresponding with that person for some time, a simple 'Bill' by itself is okay. Note that 'Dear Mr Bill' or 'Dear Bill Gates' or 'Dear Gates' is inappropriate. If you know the recipient's nickname or any name that he prefers, use that. Some of our Indianisms like 'Respected Sir' or 'Dear Bill Sir' or 'Dear technical director' are absolutely not appropriate.

Sometimes you may not be able to guess the sex of the person from the name, in which case, a neutral sounding 'Dear Dipti' (or even 'Dear Dipti Patnaik') is fine. And don't misspell the name.

Closure: Similarly, keep your e-mail closure simple. Just say 'Regards' and in the next line 'Vijay'. (If you are sending it to a total stranger, 'Sincerely' would work as well.) If you have been writing to that person several times, you can drop the 'Regards' and simply sign off as Vijay. If you want to be formal and courteous in your closure, you can use 'Cordially' or 'Sincerely'. Do not use expressions like 'Yours obediently' or 'Yours faithfully' or even worse, 'I remain, yours faithfully'.

Signature: When you are writing a business mail, we strongly recommend that you don't just sign off as 'Vijay'. Do have a standard signature that shows your full name, title and organization details (see the boxes below).

Length of an e-mail: There is no specific guideline on how long an e-mail should be. But in general, e-mails longer than a couple of screen scrolls are difficult to read and may force people to print the e-mail and read it later. Keep e-mails as short as possible. Should you really have lots of things to cover, consider giving a quick summary in the e-mail and put the rest in an attachment.

Giving the most important information upfront: Following through on the previous point, make sure you prioritize the contents of your e-mail and highlight the most important ones within the first few lines and definitely within a couple of screen scrolls.

Use of To, CC and BCC: There is a subtle difference between 'To' and 'CC'. People included in the 'To' field are primary recipients of the e-mail, whereas people who are copied are receiving the e-mail 'for their information' only, because the 'loop' includes them. If you need someone to take some action, their names *must* be on the 'To' list. If you want someone to be just informed and you require no specific actions from them, put them on a CC list. Use the BCC list sparingly, only when you don't want anyone else to know the recipient being BCC-ed.

Now let us look at some specifics of these different categories of e-mail.

32.4 WRITING ENQUIRY E-MAILS

In a corporate environment, you may have to get information from other people (see Box 32.2).

Box 32.2

Common scenarios where enquiry mails are needed in business environments

Componentized development: Today, most software products are not developed in a monolithic way. Different components are developed by different teams in an inter-dependent way and these parts have to be assembled together to form an integrated whole, which is greater than the sum of its parts. Teams may need to interact with each other and get details about the functionality of the other parts and the interfaces they offer.

Geographic work distribution: Globalization has distributed work across geographies and time zones. It is common in software to find the global delivery model, where on-shore, near-shore and off-shore teams have to work together to produce complex pieces of software; in ITeS work originates in one place and gets executed in another location miles away. In manufacturing, design comes from different locations and the actual manufacturing occurs elsewhere. If all the teams are in one location, you can walk across to your colleague's office down the hall and ask him for any clarifications. But, with geographic separation and time zone differences, this option is foreclosed. E-mail is your only saviour.

Large organizations: When organizations grow in size, they become rather impersonal. When combined with geographical distribution of people and tasks, the only formal means of communication available, that is fast, economical and easy to use is e-mail. For example, you may need to find out about the problems encountered by customers by communicating with the customer-support personnel. The customer may be in New York, you may be in Bangalore and the customer support may be in Sydney. In such cases, e-mails are the best formal means of communication that leave behind a trail and resolve issues quickly.

Let us look at some practical problems in making such enquiries.

- ▶ First of all, you may not know where or to whom to send your enquiry e-mail. Large organizations tend to operate in silos in a somewhat impersonal way. For you to find out the right person to contact is sometimes not very easy.
- ▶ Even if you find out the right recipient, the person you send the e-mail to may not enjoy getting the e-mail or may simply choose to ignore your e-mail.
- ▶ If you are under time-pressure to get answers to your enquiries, that might compound the problem a bit more.

So how do you resolve this fundamental issue of whom to send the mail to?

- ▶ If it is an internal enquiry, you can determine who to send the e-mail to by looking up the intranet directory; usually most corporate intranets provide an easily searchable directory.

- ▶ Look up any work products like program source code or documents that you can lay your hands on. The person who last changed this program code or document would be a good place to start with.
- ▶ Use your network. You might have talked to someone in that group in a conference or a training programme. Dig out his contact information, pick up the phone and revive the contact. If that someone helped you with the e-mail ID of a valid contact, it is good manners to 'CC' the e-mail to that person as well, provided the matter you discuss in the e-mail is not confidential.
- ▶ Sometimes even a generic e-mail to the associate @customer_service kind of address might do the trick.
- ▶ Sometimes you may have to send your e-mail to multiple people in order to increase the probability of your enquiry getting answered. This should be your last resort, since whenever you send a mail to multiple people, each of the recipients may assume that someone else will respond back to the enquiry.

Once you find out whom to contact, there are a few more factors that you need to consider to make your enquiry effective (i.e. for you to get the information you want). These are:

- ▶ Use of subject line
- ▶ Simple introduction
- ▶ Building in some defense
- ▶ Proper wording of the enquiry
- ▶ Closure.

We have already seen the general guidelines to use for choosing an appropriate subject line. In addition to those discussed earlier, the following guidelines would be useful when you are sending an enquiry mail, especially to an unknown person.

- ▶ A subject line that specifies the topic of the enquiry that is likely to arouse interest in the recipient: e.g., *'Storage options: Request for information'*. Note that the topic (storage options) comes before the phrase 'Request for Information'. This is because the topic itself is likely to arouse more interest than the 'request for information'.
- ▶ A subject line that gives the name of the person who referred you to the person to whom you are sending the mail: e.g., *'Referral by John Collins: Storage options info request'*. If John Collins carries clout and is known to the recipient, this is likely to cause the recipient to open the mail.
- ▶ A subject line that carries a credible institution name: e.g., *'From IIT-Chennai: Request info on storage options'*. This again builds credibility by the name of the institution and adds to the interest of the subject matter (storage options).

A simple introduction of yourself is needed right at the outset, because the recipient probably does not know who you are or what exactly your functional role is in your organization. A possible introduction has been illustrated in Box 32.3.

Box 32.3

EFFECTIVE INTRODUCTIONS: EXAMPLE

I would like to introduce myself as Vijay Raghavan from Desi Computers Inc. in India. As you may be aware, Desi Computers Inc. manages MIRACLE's security environment. I am in charge of maintaining the directory and security database.

Note that the introduction clearly brings out your first and last name, your organization and your role in the organization—which set the tone for the authenticity and relevance of the body of the message (see Box 32.4 for same ineffective introduction).

Box 32.4

INEFFECTIVE INTRODUCTIONS: EXAMPLES

- ▶ 'I am Vijay. I am in charge of your security.' *(very abrupt, does not have sufficient context)*
- ▶ 'In my role as the directory administrator, I am . . .' *(again, not providing sufficient context and does not give the name)*
- ▶ 'I am Vijay, a distinguished graduate of IIT. I am currently at Desi Computers Inc., which was founded. . . .' *(very wordy and rambling)*

The next aspect of an enquiry e-mail is that you should build in some defence. You are sending this mail to get the information you want. You do not necessarily know whether the recipient is the correct one for the subject or whether he will help you. At the least, the recipient should not feel irritated by getting your e-mail. If he is not the right person to service your request, he should be happy to refer you to the right person or forward your e-mail to that person. A typical example of such a defence has been given in Box 32.5.

Box 32.5

I am looking for some information on LDAP security. Your name was suggested by your colleague Ms Mary Angelene. *(Note that we are establishing rapport and credibility, assuming Mary's name is well known to the recipient.)*

I would appreciate it if you could help me in this. If this issue is not in your group, I offer my sincere apologies. *(Again, note that you are preempting any feeling of anger by this apology.)* I would appreciate it if you could pass this on to anyone whom you think could help. *(You have stated what you want in a polite way.)*

(State your request)

Thanks in advance. *(Again a very courteous end to the mail that will make it difficult for the person to yell at you.)*

Regarding the enquiry proper, let the recipient see the importance, urgency and the need for your request, the sincerity of your request and the appreciation for a response. Try to remember the following points:

- ▶ Be specific; don't beat around the bush.
- ▶ Bring the crux of the matter within the first page (screen), possibly within just a few lines.
- ▶ Restrict the e-mail to a few questions; don't make it look like a laundry list
- ▶ Number the questions, so that they can respond question-by-question.
- ▶ Don't threaten a response.
- ▶ Don't give unreasonable deadlines!

But, make sure the urgency and the given deadlines are real and not fake and cooked up. And, don't use this criticality every time—that will reduce your credibility and the chances of the recipient responding to you (let alone responding to you in time).

What would you do if there is a real dependency and you must get the other person's response immediately? In this case, put some thought as to what you think is the right information to approach and state your viewpoint. If you have some idea of what the right action is and you are looking to the other person's inputs just for confirmation, you can include a default action ('deemed approval') in the mail and unless the recipient has serious disputes and expresses his reservations in a reply e-mail, the default action will be taken. For example, see Box 32.6.

Box 32.6

Looking at the issue, my understanding is that the appropriate solution is . . . Since the product release on 28 February is critically dependent on this information, can you please get back to me with any corrections by 10 February, if you feel my above understanding is not right?

Please note that this is not a foolproof method nor should this be used to cover yourself with a 'I told you so' later. Exercise caution and demonstrate professionalism in expressing the option you think is best.

Finally, have an effective, positive and courteous closure. Reaffirm your positive attitude (see Box 32.7).

Box 32.7

Since the product release on 28 February is critically dependent on this information, I look forward to your valuable inputs by 18 February and thank you in advance.

Regards
Vijay

32.5 REPORTING PROBLEMS OVER E-MAIL

A problem-reporting e-mail arises because a problem has not been adequately resolved through regular channels. As the author of such an e-mail, your motivation should be in problem-resolution and not in lambasting the other person or otherwise venting your feelings. Also, you should be quite tactful in writing such an e-mail and make sure that it coaxes the other party to buy your viewpoint and nudges him into action. You should invoke the right tone, balance and list of suggestions. Remember that people generally do not like to get negative, complaining e-mails and so, your e-mail should project that you are a reasonable person with a genuine problem that you need to solve. Remember too, that such e-mails leave a trail behind and in the rare event the situation gets complicated, your e-mail messages will serve you as a record of the sequence of events.

Direct it to the appropriate person—look at the project plan or the intranet directory or simply ask around and figure out who to hit. At first, fire your e-mails just to that person. If this doesn't work out and you need to escalate the matter, 'CC' your e-mail to the person one level above the recipient. You may want to keep your own boss in the loop and 'CC' him as well. Here too, you have to address some key elements.

Such e-mails have the following basic structure:

- ▶ Addressing/Opening salutation
- ▶ Introduction of the sender
- ▶ Facts about the subject (problem report)
- ▶ Eliciting action
- ▶ Closure/Signature

The subject line should clearly and unmistakably introduce the problem to the recipient. As mentioned earlier, the subject line should motivate the recipient to open the e-mail. Vague subject lines like 'serious problem' or 'SOS' or 'HELP!!!!!!' are inappropriate. The subject line should bring out two things: the urgency of the situation and a brief abstract of the problem being reported (see Boxes 32.8 and 32.10).

Box 32.8

Some examples of effective subject lines for problem-reporting e-mails

URGENT: A high priority security violation in the shopping cart application (*Note the word URGENT in caps and the specific description of the problem and the area.*)

Bug # 278902 from Timbuktu Airways, not resolved for 23 days (*Note the specific bug #, the customer name and how long it has been left unresolved.*)

Show Stopper: Year-end tax statements program crash at Country Bank of India (*Note the word show stopper upfront, specific information of what fails and the customer name.*)

The introduction part of the problem-reporting e-mail is similar to that of an enquiry e-mail. For example, see Box 32.9 for an effective introduction and Box 32.10 for examples of same ineffective introductions.

Box 32.9

EFFECTIVE INTRODUCTIONS

I would like to introduce myself as Vijay Raghavan from Desi Computers Inc. As you may be aware, Desi Computers Inc. manages MIRACLE's security environment. I am in charge of maintaining the directory and security database. I am writing this note because of an unresolved, critical problem in the security environment that we have not been able to resolve through the normal channels. *(Note that the writer has introduced himself, his role and the specific problem he is encountering and that the problem is not resolved through normal channels—all in a matter of four lines.)*

Box 32.10

Not-so-effective introductions:

- ▶ 'I am Vijay. I am in charge of your security and there is a nagging problem.' *(Not a specific description; also a very negative word 'nagging' and on the surface, unsubstantiated.)*
- ▶ 'There is the problem . . . which I have tried umpteen times to resolve but feels like I am knocking my head against the wall. Can't you guys resolve these simple issues?' *(Very condescending—this mail can invoke fear but not perhaps co-operation from the recipient. He may resolve this problem, but you might have burnt the bridge for resolving future problems.)*

In order to get the best result adhere to the following:

- ▶ Report the problem clearly. Don't mince words trying to be nice or trying to report a problem that is not really important or urgent.
- ▶ State the original expectation and what the problem was. As we said in Chapter 8, satisfaction coming out of performance depends on the expectation setting.
- ▶ If possible, quote instances where the normal expectations have so far been met.
- ▶ Present facts to prove the existence of the problem, but do not over-inundate with data. Use only objective data and do not make claims that cannot be substantiated.

- ▶ Number the specific concerns you have so that they can respond to you concern by concern. Restrict to just a few so that you don't look like a perpetual moaner and end up getting solutions for none of the things.
- ▶ As with enquiry e-mails, don't sound threatening or give the recipient unreasonable deadlines.
- ▶ And finally, don't make any personal, caste- or gender-based remarks.

It is generally a good idea to have a separate, new paragraph for 'eliciting action'. Here you insist on a time-bound, reasonable and objective resolution of your problem. Be firm, but courteous. For example, see Box 32.11.

Box 32.11

Given the serious impact the availability of hardware has on our business, I would like to see the hardware (MBI Terminal Controller 3701, with 8MB cache, which is what was originally agreed upon) commissioned at my site in the next two weeks (i.e., before 15 February 2009). Please confirm the specific date of delivery by this weekend so that I can make sure my system administrator is available.

Regards
 Vijay,
 Vijay Raghavan,
 MIRACLE Security Administrator,
 Desi Computers Inc.,
 234 Infantry Road
 Bangalore 560001
 Vijay.raghavan@desi.com
 Ph: +91-80-2890-9809

For a problem reporting e-mail, the closure should have a full signature with the role of the sender so that the credibility and authenticity of the sender is established. Since there is already a call for action, no specific reaffirmation is required.

32.6 RESPONDING TO PROBLEMS OVER E-MAIL

The purpose of this type of e-mail is to respond to a problem assigned to you—either directly or by your manager. Responding to problems over e-mail requires certain mindset changes that you have to make in yourself.

- ▶ You have to be just as tactful, courteous and professional about writing these e-mails as in problem-reporting e-mails. Just as your aim in sending a problem

report was to get your problem resolved, here also, your aim should be to resolve the sender's problem.

- ▶ Show understanding of the other person and his observation. Empathize with him. This does not mean you are agreeing that you are in the wrong. All you are telling the other party is that 'Okay, I understand you have a problem; let us work together and resolve this. I am equally interested in solving this problem.'
- ▶ Even if your instincts say otherwise, rein in your emotions. (It gets even more ugly and unpleasant if the sender copies several other people in the organization and escalates the matter.)
- ▶ Work towards resolving the real problem underneath the complaint. Don't be on the path to assign blame to any particular person.

No one likes to be told that there is a problem in what they do. Even though we asked that you should rein in emotions, it is easier said than done. What you don't want to do is type a nasty e-mail to the person who reported the problem and send it to the recipient before you have edited it, by mistake. Hence, we strongly recommend that you type the response offline in a notepad or word processing document, print and check it, make changes as appropriate and finally copy that into your mail and send it across.

Be very clear about who all should receive your reply. Some considerations in this regard are:

- ▶ Should your manager be cc-ed if he was not copied in the original complaint e-mail? Use your discretion. If the problem is not a very serious one, don't bug your manager. Save a copy for yourself and if needed you can show it to your manager or include it in your weekly status report.
- ▶ Should you copy the sender's manager? We would strongly recommend not to do this as it would sound confrontational and is likely to make the recipient more defensive and refuse to accept your solution.
- ▶ Should *you* escalate the matter to a higher level? Should you forward the original e-mail and your reply to any other persons? Again, unless it is a serious issue, we recommend that you do not escalate the mail or cc it to unnecessary people when replying.

The subject line is usually not an issue for these mails, because normally you would just need to hit the 'reply' button for the original mail. But, if there are too many replies and forwards, it is a good idea to refresh the subject line to avoid the multiple 'Re's and 'Fwd's that take up all the initial characters of the subject line.

In the body of the e-mail, there is no need to have an elaborate introduction since the sender probably knows who you are (or your role in the organization). Always start with a courteous and short preamble and apologize right away for the inconvenience caused, irrespective of what or who caused the problem (see Box 32.12).

Box 32.12

Thanks for the mail expressing your concerns. Let me take this opportunity to reassure you that things are under control and also address the specific points you have brought up.

If the problem message has a numbered list of problems, take them one by one. Even if the problem is not broken into components by the sender, see if you can paraphrase the problems by something like:

If I may re-state the issues you have brought up, they are:

- 1..
- 2..

Respond to the concerns with clear objective data, not just your perspective. Clearly document resolutions or actions for each item with 'what-who-when'.

Don't be overly defensive. But do not assume that you are always right or flawless. Be objective and focus only on the specific problem and present a solution that is mutually satisfactory. Do resist the temptation of 'getting one back'. Conclude with restating major action items and your (that is, your organization's) intent on customer satisfaction. For example, see Box 32.13.

Box 32.13

I hope that I have addressed all the points that you have brought up in the mail. I once again reiterate our commitment to achieving the common goals and would follow up on taking these action items to completion. I will get in touch with you again a week from now, by when the database backup issue should be resolved.

Regards

Vijay,

Vijay Raghavan,

MIRACLE Security Administrator,

Desi Computers Inc.,

234 Infantry Road

Bangalore 560001

Vijay.raghavan@desi.com

Ph: +91-80-2890-9809

Do keep your promises. Make a follow-through phone call after reaching a reasonable milestone. It is important to register small victories so as to restore or increase customer confidence. Follow the call after such a successful milestone with an e-mail, such as the one in Box 32.14.

Box 32.14

Thanks for taking the time for the call we had this morning. I am glad that everything is going as per schedule and we have achieved our first milestone towards resolving the database backup issue. I will follow up next week. In the meanwhile, if there are any specific issues you want to bring up, do not hesitate to e-mail / call me directly.

Regards
Vijay,
Vijay Raghavan,
MIRACLE Security Administrator,
Desi Computers Inc.,
234 Infantry Road
Bangalore 560001
Vijay.raghavan@desi.com
Ph: +91-80-2890-9809

Remember people do not care how much you know until they know how much you care!

32.7 SENDING MINUTES OF MEETING OVER E-MAIL

The next genre is meeting minutes e-mail (which also encompasses minutes of conference calls and so on). These missives are aimed at all the attendees, including those people who should have attended the meeting, but missed it for some reason. Typically, a comprehensive mailing list is made at the beginning of the project and updated periodically. The mail should be 'CC'-ed to all the relevant managers, people who have been assigned action items and any administrative persons, as necessary. The subject line should be crisp e.g., 'Meeting minutes—Lotto Lotteries Project—13 September 2009'.

The body of the e-mail should include the following information:

- ▶ Meeting at: (location)
- ▶ Attendees:
 - Lotto Lotteries (customer):
 - Desi Computers Inc.:
 - (Names of those present and also of those absent)
- ▶ Agenda items:
- ▶ Discussions and decisions:
- ▶ Highlights:
- ▶ Red alerts:

- ▶ What action? Impact? Worst case (when required)?
- ▶ Action Items
- ▶ Who-when-what.

Prepare this offline and it is best to have a designated 'scribe' assigned to this task. Have a table of contents, with hyperlinks to other items in the message. Make sure highlights and appropriate red alerts come within the first two pages and make sure you don't 'hide' action items within details! Wherever required, seek feedback within a clear deadline.

32.8 STATUS REPORTS AND OTHER TYPES OF REPORTS

Status reports (and other reports like trip reports) are typically sent over e-mail. Part of the purpose of such e-mails is to archive a particular set of findings/observations and keep it as reference. The main report itself should be a Word document attached to the e-mail, with only the 'hook' of the report featured in the body of the e-mail. We have already covered writing status reports in Chapter 26.

32.9 MISCELLANEOUS TOPICS

Here we will cover some miscellaneous etiquette considerations while sending e-mails:

Use of Attachments

- ▶ Avoid attachments if you can. Keep any short narrative inline; use attachments only when it is large or cannot be contained in under a couple of screens.
- ▶ Zip or compress anything other than a 'simple document', especially those that contain graphics and animations. But be forewarned that some organizations ban the use of such files as attachments.
- ▶ Avoid sending executables as attachment because of potential virus threats.
- ▶ Send only something small (our recommendation: < 5 MB); else post on a site and give the URL.
- ▶ Send only to those who absolutely need to see it.

E-mail IDs, Use of Signature and Footer

Most organizations have definite standards in assigning e-mail IDs to users. (Typically, <first name>.<last name>@<companyname>.com)

Even if no standards are enforced, choose a clear and meaningful e-mail ID, which reflects your name. Weird handles, nick-names and anonymous-sounding IDs are not proper in a business setting (e.g., avoid things like smartestone@myhome.com or jamesbond@myco.com).

It is also okay to have a descriptive signature file that you can use at the end of your e-mail (see Box 32.15).

Box 32.15

Vijay,
Vijay Raghavan,
MIRACLE Security Administrator,
Desi Computers Inc.,
234 Infantry Road
Bangalore 560001
Vijay.raghavan@desi.com
Ph: +91-80-2890-9809

Small talk, e-mail style

It is not out of character to indulge in a bit of small talk in e-mails to people who are somewhat familiar to you. This is especially appropriate if you are e-mailing to your group members in a different geographical location. For example, see Box 32.16.

Box 32.16

'The monsoons are here. Let me know when you are coming over, so that I can give you some monsoon survival tips. . . '

You can introduce other personal touches as well. But remember that these things should be interesting enough that they instantly endear you to the recipient.

Some more miscellaneous points

- ▶ Be prompt in replying to e-mails, especially those that solicit information or request the resolution of a problem. Don't treat it as a very low-priority activity.
- ▶ Avoid chain mails and cascade forwarding.
- ▶ Don't use sexist or chauvinistic phrases or mails with offensive jokes.
- ▶ Do not copy your official mail to your personal mail ID on public accounts (Yahoo, Gmail, etc.).
- ▶ There is no place for profanity or swearing or in indecent language.
- ▶ Try to spell right, although cryptic spellings (and acronyms like IMHO and LOL) are increasingly being used and accepted.
- ▶ Avoid using all capital (upper case) letters.
- ▶ Do not send highly personal or intimate e-mails—remember your business e-mail should be so staid that they can be read by your boss or CEO.
- ▶ Remember your liability to yourself and your company!
- ▶ Use neutral date formats (like 13 September 2009, instead of 02/05/09).
- ▶ E-mails are not SMS messages. They should not be one-liners.

32.10 CHAT, BLOGS AND TWITTERS

Although chats, blogs and tweets on Twitter are not yet the mainstream modes of business communication, they have their place in the modern business universe and who knows, they might become important channels of communication in future.

Chats or 'same time' or Instant Messaging (IM) or whatever they are called in your organization offer a real-time opportunity to get into a 'chat-room' full of people who log into the service. The advantage here is that unlike e-mails, you will know whether your party is in the chat-room and available. If so, you may be able to 'talk' to him back and forth and extract his immediate response on things. But unlike in e-mails, you will have to keep your communication terse and ask only simple questions. The other advantage is that since a lot of people in your group may be logged into the same chat-room, you already have a ready forum for an impromptu, albeit simple, discussion. If you are into social networking (Orkut, Facebook, etc.), make absolutely sure that your social activities are kept separate from your business communication.

The blog and its cousin, Twitter have now become well-established. Both can be ideal media for 'broadcasting' technical and product development information or for educating your customers about your company's products, philosophy, policies and so on. Forums associated with blogs can be good places to communicate with end customers and spread your organization's message. But blogs and Twitters are highly time-sensitive and critically dependent on being updated regularly. And finally, you will have to clear your blogging or tweeting activity—even your personal and non

work-related blogs—with your organization before embarking on it, to make sure that there is no conflict of interest.



"You've got mail. But anyway you are not going to read it and so, I am going to put it in Trash....."

Fig. 32.1

32.11 IN SUMMARY

Email has indeed evolved from just simple text to much richer presentation styles; from just the pride of the elite to a necessary activity for every individual in an organization doing any type of business. As you take up a career in any line of business, emails and its new avatars like tweets and blogs will doubtless become part of your identity. The tips given in this chapter will hopefully make that identity more effective.